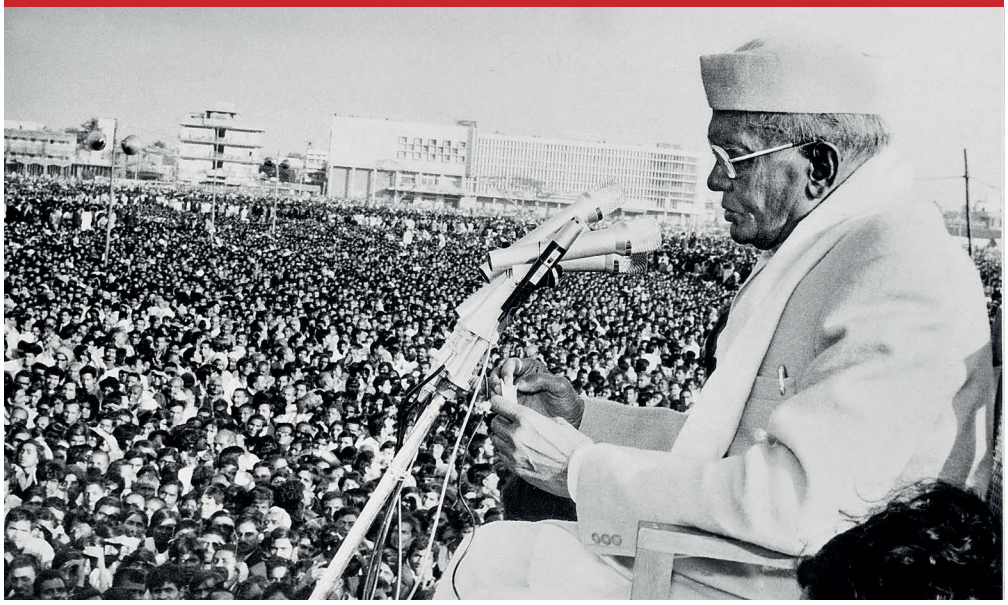
YOUTH IN REVOLT

Three major movements that demonstrated the power of youth mobilisation to shape Indian politics and society

JP'S TOTAL REVOLUTION *(1974-75)* ▶

ISSUE: Opposition to corruption, price rise and misgovernance under the Congress rule, culminating in **Jayaprakash Narayan**'s call for *Sampoorna Kranti*

YOUTH'S ROLE: Students in Bihar initiated the agitation and invited JP to lead it. The movement soon spread beyond Bihar, with youth at its core. It challenged Indira Gandhi's government and contributed to the political crisis that preceded the Emergency. This, in turn, helped unite opposition forces under JP, leading to the formation of the Janata Party, which defeated her in the 1977 election.



he warns. That exposes the CJP's first fundamental choice. Is it trying to improve the system issue by issue, or attempting to acquire enough power to alter the system itself? Both require tremendous organisational abilities.

Raising the Cockroach Army

India's unmet agendas give the CJP its opportunity, building an organisation into a viable national political force is its great vulnerability. As psephologist Sanjay Kumar, professor at the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies in Delhi, points out, "A successful movement does not automatically produce a successful party." History, he says, offers contrasting lessons on converting agitation into electoral power. The six-year Assam students' agitation (1979-1985) spawned the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), which swept to power in the 1985 assembly polls. But the Uttarakhand Kranti Dal (UKD), a leading force in the long struggle to carve a separate hill state out of Uttar Pradesh, failed to capitalise on that triumph when Uttarakhand was finally created in 2000 and was reduced to a marginal electoral force.

Kumar points to an even bigger hurdle. "The CJP will be confronting a formidable opponent in the BJP. So, it may be better off starting small—proving itself in a state or a handful of constituencies—rather than imagining itself immediately as a national alternative." The BJP-RSS ecosystem, after all, has been built over generations, with cadres, booth committees and grassroots networks capable of countering, containing or co-opting challengers. Yet Hansen of Stanford University sees a potential weakness. "The BJP has built a 20th-century political machine around physical networks, grassroots organisers and disciplined mobilisation. But will that prove as decisive in the social media age, when the CJP has demonstrated the power of speed, digital reach and horizontal connectivity?"

CJP HAS A FORMIDABLE OPPONENT IN BJP, WHICH HAS BUILT AN ECOSYSTEM OVER SEVERAL GENERATIONS, WITH CADRES AS WELL AS GRASSROOTS NETWORKS

The CJP's 'Brahmastra', as a Dipke associate describes it, is social media. 'School Thik Karo' offers a glimpse of how that weapon works. Local Instagrammers and content creators audit village schools; the CJP's central handle then shares their reels, amplifying a hyperlocal complaint into a potentially national conversation. Ajay Dandekar, an academician, sees something genuinely novel in this. The CJP's ground mobilisation, he says, grows out of a social media interaction that is "almost autonomous and immune to outside pulls and pressures". The consequence has not always been orderly—there have been hasty articulations and missteps—but Dandekar believes that the sudden opening up of public expression is "an extremely healthy sign for our democracy".

Yet followers are not cadre. And the CJP knows this. It is putting together national structures covering policy, legal affairs, finance, technology, media and administration. Baliyan has been tasked with building the ground organisation. His test for prospective volunteers is refreshingly mundane: "How much time can you give to this? How far do you see yourself going? How far can you run around?" That is the unglamorous work on which movements survive after the algorithm moves on. And the CJP has a considerable way